What Actually Changes Minds

A working guide and worksheet for testing your own beliefs — and for the conversations where someone else's are on the line

How to use this

This is a worksheet, not a test. Nothing here scores you, and no one sees it. The exercises only work if you write in them — actually write, in the boxes, in whatever order the words come out. The thinking that happens in your head while you read is not the same thinking that happens when you have to put a number on a line or finish a sentence.

Work through it in order the first time. After that, use Part One on its own as a diagnostic, any time you notice yourself feeling very certain about something.

> The one-line version: you cannot detect your own overconfidence by introspection, because it feels exactly like being right. So you have to run procedures, not check feelings.

Part One

Catching your own overreach

1. Put a number on it

Vague conviction can't be examined. A number can. Choose one belief you hold with real confidence — not a trivial one, something you would defend in an argument if someone pushed.

THE BELIEF, STATED IN ONE SENTENCE

Now the number. Write your first instinct, before you think about it further. The number you arrive at after deliberation is a negotiation; the first one is the honest reading.

HOW CONFIDENT ARE YOU, AS A PERCENTAGE?

WHAT PERCENTAGE WOULD YOU NEED BEFORE ACTING ON IT?

WHAT PERCENTAGE DID YOU HOLD FIVE YEARS AGO?

Now list what the number actually rests on. Be specific — a book, a person, a year, an experience. "It's obvious" is not an entry.

EVIDENCE OR EXPERIENCE I CAN NAME SPECIFICALLY	WHERE IT CAME FROM	COULD I BE WRONG ABOUT THIS?

> If the evidence column is short and the confidence number is high, that gap is what the rest of this part is for.

2. The explanation test

This is the strongest single exercise in the guide. Research on the illusion of explanatory depth found that people's confidence in their understanding drops sharply the moment they try to explain a thing in detail — with nobody arguing against them and no new information arriving. Being asked "how does it actually work?" does work that a debate usually fails to do.

So explain it. Not why you believe it — how the thing itself works. Mechanically, in order, to someone who knows nothing about it. Where does it come from, what makes it go, what would break it?

Rate yourself again, on the same scale.

CONFIDENCE BEFORE EXPLAINING (%)

CONFIDENCE AFTER EXPLAINING (%)

THE PART I DISCOVERED I COULDN'T ACTUALLY EXPLAIN

> A drop here is not a defeat. It is the most useful thing that will happen to you this week.

3. What would change your mind

Answer honestly, because there's a specific failure mode to catch. When the answer turns out to be "nothing," that is rarely a statement about the evidence. It's a statement about what the belief is doing for you.

WHAT SPECIFIC, FINDABLE THING WOULD CHANGE MY MIND? BE CONCRETE — A DOCUMENT, A MEASUREMENT, A NAMED PERSON'S TESTIMONY, AN OUTCOME THAT HASN'T HAPPENED YET.

Now tick whichever of these is also true, even slightly.

- [ ] Nothing would — the question feels faintly insulting
- [ ] I'd want it to come from my side, not theirs
- [ ] I can name it, but I've already decided it doesn't exist or wouldn't be credible
- [ ] I can name it, and I'd genuinely move — from 85% down to 60%, say
- [ ] I'd accept it in principle, but the people who say it are acting in bad faith

The first four are the same answer in different clothes. If you ticked one of them, the useful question isn't "am I right?" — it's "what is this belief holding up?" That's Part Two.

4. The asymmetry audit

We hold our own side and the other side to different standards, and it doesn't feel that way from the inside — it feels like their claims are simply weaker. This makes the difference visible.

QUESTION	A CLAIM I ACCEPT FAIRLY EASILY	A CLAIM THEY MAKE THAT I REJECT
What standard of proof do I demand?		
What's my default assumption about their motives?		
What's the most generous reading of their position?		
What would I say if a friend held their view?		
How would I put it if I had to say it to them, in person?		

> The gap between the two columns is the measurement. You don't have to close it today. You have to see it.

5. When certainty arrives too fast

Certainty is a feeling produced before the reasoning, not after it. These are the circumstances in which that feeling is least trustworthy. Tick any that describe how you came to this belief.

- [ ] I formed it quickly — one sitting, or one sitting's worth of reading
- [ ] It arrived attached to a strong emotion: anger, relief, vindication
- [ ] It made me part of a group I wanted to belong to
- [ ] The story was unusually neat; it explained a great deal at once
- [ ] I have never had to defend it to someone who knew more than I did
- [ ] Everyone I actually talk to agrees with me
- [ ] Most of what I've read about it is things I already agreed with
- [ ] I felt this way before I could have explained why

Three of these together describe a belief formed by something other than evidence. That doesn't make it false. It means you don't yet have a reason to trust it.

6. Reading sideways

The most portable habit in the whole literature: stop reading down the page and start reading across sources. A page can look completely reliable and be entirely wrong — professional design is cheap. What a page cannot fake is what independent sources say about it.

A CLAIM I CURRENTLY ACCEPT ON THE STRENGTH OF ONE SOURCE

TWO SOURCES THAT DON'T SHARE AN ORIGIN WITH IT — AND WHAT I'D LOOK FOR IN EACH

WHAT THEY AGREE ON

WHAT THEY DISAGREE ON

WHAT NONE OF THEM MENTION

Part Two

What it costs to change

7. The cost ledger

People rarely fail to update because they can't do the arithmetic. They fail because the belief is doing a job. Before asking why someone won't move — including yourself — work out what dropping it would cost. Be specific and unsentimental.

WHAT I'D HAVE TO GIVE UP	WHAT IT WOULD COST (1–5)	COULD I SURVIVE IT?

For most people the costs fall into a few buckets. Tick the ones that are actually true for you.

- ☐ Admitting I was wrong to people who heard me be certain
- ☐ Losing standing in a group I belong to
- ☐ Having to redo a decision I've already made and defended
- ☐ Giving up a story about myself — that I'm careful, or that I see through things
- ☐ Conceding that people I've dismissed were partly right
- ☐ Losing the comfort of the explanation itself
- ☐ Honestly? Very little.

> If the last box is the true one, you're in a small minority and this belief should be easy to move. If the others are, evidence alone won't do it — because the evidence isn't competing with your belief. It's competing with the cost.

8. The conditions audit

These are the conditions under which people demonstrably reconsider. You can't install all of them at once, but you can see which are missing — from a situation of your own, or from a conversation you're about to have.

CONDITION	PRESENT / PARTLY / ABSENT	WHAT'S MISSING
There's no audience I'm performing for		
The goal is accuracy, not winning		
I could keep my dignity while changing		
The person I'm talking to isn't conditional on my agreeing		
I'm being asked, not told		
I have time, and nothing is urgent		
I know someone who holds the other view and is decent		
I'd have somewhere to go if I left this belief behind		

The audience line deserves its own note. Being accountable to an audience you can't see, whose views you don't know, produces more careful and more self-critical thinking. Being accountable to an audience you can see — whose approval you want — produces more bias. This is why beliefs harden in rooms and soften in correspondence.

9. The thing not to do

The failure mode is consistent enough to write down before you open your mouth. Clinical practice has a name for it: the righting reflex — the urge to correct, to supply the answer, to point at the error. When someone is genuinely ambivalent, arguing for the change makes them argue against it, because you've just occupied the side they needed to stand on themselves.

- [ ] I'm about to explain why they're wrong
- [ ] I've prepared facts they didn't ask for
- [ ] I'm going to say something that implies they're stupid or brainwashed
- [ ] I need them to admit it out loud, to me
- [ ] I've already decided what changing their mind should look like
- [ ] I'll keep going until they concede

> Each of these is a documented way to delay the outcome you want. Being told you're stupid, or brainwashed, or a dupe comes up again and again in first-person accounts as the thing that made people dig in — not because the accusation was false, but because accepting it would have meant accepting the humiliation.

Part Three

The conversation

10. Plan the exit before the argument

Nobody changes their mind and walks off a cliff. The most useful thing you can offer another person is a change that's survivable — and that's a design problem you can work on before anyone speaks.

THE BELIEF, AND WHAT IT CURRENTLY DOES FOR THEM — BELONGING, IDENTITY, SAFETY, COMFORT, A GRUDGE

WHAT CHANGING IT WOULD COST THEM, SPECIFICALLY, AND IN FRONT OF WHOM

WHAT A DIGNIFIED VERSION OF CHANGING THEIR MIND WOULD LOOK LIKE. WHAT COULD THEY SAY THAT ISN'T "I WAS AN IDIOT"?

11. What actually to do

The research and the personal accounts agree on a short list, and almost none of it is arguing. Tick what you're willing to try.

- [ ] Ask what they think, then stay quiet long enough for the real answer
- [ ] Be the person who contradicts the belief by existing, without needing to win
- [ ] Be willing to be the one who moves
- [ ] Ask how it works — invite the explanation, and let the gaps do the work
- [ ] Keep the relationship unconditional, and say so out loud
- [ ] Ask what would change their mind, and receive the answer without correcting it
- [ ] Leave the exit open — make clear that changing their mind wouldn't lower your opinion of them

THE ONE QUESTION I'LL ACTUALLY ASK

THE THING I WON'T SAY, EVEN IF IT'S TRUE

Part Four

Your own changes, examined

12. A belief you've already changed

You've done this before. Almost everyone has, at least once, on something that mattered. Your own history is better evidence than any study here, because it tells you which mechanism actually worked on you.

THE BELIEF I USED TO HOLD

WHAT I BELIEVE NOW

ROUGHLY HOW LONG THE CHANGE TOOK

Now work backwards through the five things that recur in accounts of changed minds. Write what happened — or write "nothing," because the absence is information too.

1. THE CRACK — AN EXPERIENCE OR FACT THE OLD BELIEF COULDN'T ACCOUNT FOR

2. THE WITNESS — A PERSON WHO CONTRADICTED THE BELIEF SIMPLY BY BEING WHO THEY WERE

3. THE COST — SOMETHING I LOST, RISKED, OR COULD NO LONGER AVOID BY HOLDING IT

4. THE PERMISSION — SOMEONE, OR SOMETHING, THAT MADE CHANGING NOT A HUMILIATION

5. THE NEW STORY — HOW I BECAME A PERSON WHO CHANGED WITHOUT BEING A DUPE

WHICH ONE DID THE WORK?

AND WHICH ONE, IF IT HAD BEEN MISSING, WOULD HAVE STOPPED ME?

> Most people find the witness and the permission did more than the argument. If that's your answer too, notice what it implies about your plans for other people.

Part Five

A practice, not a position

13. The weekly four

None of this holds if it's done once. These are small on purpose — small enough to repeat.

PRACTICE	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE
One number	Pick a live belief and write the confidence percentage before you read anything else about it
One explanation	Explain something you think you understand, in writing, to nobody
One sideways read	Check a claim you like against two sources that don't share an origin with it
One conversation	Ask someone what they think about something contested, and don't correct them

14. The tracker

One row a week. In the middle column, note the average confidence across the beliefs you examined that week. If it never moves, you're probably not choosing real beliefs.

WEEK OF	WHAT I TESTED	WHAT HAPPENED	AVG. CONFIDENCE

The short version

Tear this off

If you can't state what would change your mind, the belief isn't empirical. Ask what it's holding up.

Your confidence is a feeling that arrives before your reasons. Put a number on it, then try to explain the mechanism to someone who knows nothing.

Read across sources, not down a page. A page can look reliable and be wrong; what other sources say about it can't be faked.

People change when the cost of holding on exceeds the cost of letting go — and when letting go is survivable. Plan the exit before the argument.

Be the person who contradicts the belief by existing. Be the exit that stays open. Ask more than you tell.

Almost nobody changes their mind because they were told they were stupid.

> Drawn from: research on the illusion of explanatory depth (Rozenblit & Keil; Fernbach and colleagues), accountability and bias (Tetlock), identity-protective cognition (Kahan), corrections and the failed backfire-effect replication (Wood & Porter; Nyhan & Reifler), motivational interviewing (Miller & Rollnick), and first-person accounts of changed minds — Daryl Davis, Derek Black, Megan Phelps-Roper.